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Bibliotherapy

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THE PHILOSOPHER, the critic, and the artist through the centuries have attributed to the imaginative writer not only intuitive understanding of man's motives and his nature but also power to influence his thinking, to move his heart, and even to alter his behavior. More recently psychiatrists and psychologists have acknowledged that the novelist and playwright have plumbed the deep reaches of man's nature and often anticipated the discoveries of science. Bibliotherapy, drawing upon the insights of both artist and scientist, is grounded in the theory that there is an integral relationship between the dynamics of the personality and the nature of vicarious experience. It is a process of dynamic interaction between the personality of the reader and imaginative literature which may engage his emotions and free them for conscious and productive use.

Facets of Bibliotherapy

Bibliotherapy is made possible by the "shock of recognition" the reader experiences when he beholds himself, or those close to him, in a story or some other piece of literature. So successfully does the skilled writer create an illusion of reality that, as Freud says, "he is able to guide the current of our emotions, dam it up in one direction and make it flow in another." What is the nature of this interaction

that may result, on the one hand, in distortion of the author's meaning and self deception or, on the other hand, in understanding and insight?

Reading, like all other human behavior, is a function of the total personality. When we read fiction or drama, no less than when we work, meet people, teach, create, or love, we perceive in accordance with our needs, goals, defenses, and values. Parallel in substance and function to the primary phases of psychotherapy, the vicarious experience induced by reading includes: (1) identification, including projection and introjection, (2) catharsis, and (3) insight. The reader will abstract from the work of art only what he is able to perceive and organize. Hence, he may introject meaning that will satisfy his needs and reject meaning that is threatening to his ego. In either case what he experiences and feels determines what he perceives in the book and what meaning he attaches to it.

Bibliotherapy, like deep therapy, can be effective in breaking the circular processes in perceiving. These include the recurrent ideas which lend support to our image of ourselves and of our relationship to others and the practice of confusing real experience with the symbol, and of reacting to the symbol as we do to our own emotional conflicts. In deep therapy the relationship between therapist and

patient provides an external frame of reference by means of the transference, which may free the patient by enabling him to re-live early traumatic experiences in an atmosphere of neutrality and acceptance. If the therapy is successful, he will gradually be able to differentiate between the early fear or guilt or hate and its later symbolic recurrence. Thereby he may acquire a new perspective of his experience and of himself in relation to it, an insight that liberates him from the bondage it has imposed. Similarly, bibliotherapy provides a comparable situation for "breaking the vicious circle." It offers a new frame of reference which extends the reader's awareness and enriches his understanding. The degree to which his experience is extended depends upon the strength of the emotional attitudes evoked. If a character strongly arrests his attention, and identification may be made which, in effect, represents a transference of emotion from a previous experience to the vicarious experience. A positive identification is one that tends to enhance the reader's self regard and may provide a model for emulation. A negative identification is usually engendered because of threat to his image of himself and takes the form of projection on to the character the feelings which have been repressed because they are unacceptable to the ego. However, in inducing these projections, the reading process may serve as a catalyst to free his emotions from their unconscious roots. Murray has pointed out:

It is better to make allies than

enemies of one's emotions. To rid oneself of troublesome projections one must become aware of them . . .

Literature as Experience

Literature in its direct and concrete representation of life engages the emotions and enables the reader to re-live his own experience. He may then view it freshly from the perspective of the detached observer rather than imbedded in the conventional summations of experience which often take the form of simple and unrealistic clichés about life such as, "It always works out for the best"; "It was meant to be"; "Mother knows best." In a work of literature the artist has organized the chaotic fragments of human experience, endowing them with meaning, but not imposing judgment. It is of the very essence of fiction or drama to depict experience differing only in degree from that of the reader. Hence attitudes of anger and contempt, sympathy and understanding, are inevitably invoked. One cannot remain neutral in the presence of human beings in action. Literature, being at once phantasy and reality, permits the reader an illusion of standing apart and of being involved. Thus he is able to be both spectator and participant. Under the impact of emotion he may move about in a symbolic world which is inaccessible to him in life. He will bring to bear on a fictional situation, his predispositions, the circumstances of his life, his unique perspective, and in adding them up in relation to what is given, he may be compelled to re-evaluate his own experience.

On the other hand, vicarious experience may be too threatening to the reader's concept of himself to permit what has been repressed to become conscious. Instead of viewing his own life in a new frame of reference, which may result in a more realistic appraisal of his experience, he may project his anxieties and fears upon the characters the artist has created. However, even this seeming failure to gain insight offers valuable clues in a therapeutic approach to reading. It enables the instructor to understand the motivations of the reader, to recognize his defenses, and to give them support.

We have said that the nature of vicarious experience is determined by the personality of the reader; hence it may simply reflect his concept of himself, his relationship to others, and his view of the world, but it may also transform them. The illustrations that follow suggest how the reader's recognition of himself augments his self regard, gives him a feeling of belonging, and enables him to become aware of facets of his experience that he heretofore did not acknowledge. We shall note how a simple identification with a character may result in strengthening the reader's defenses and providing a rationalization for his failure; and how it may culminate in re-living a disturbing experience, in reappraisal of himself and those close to himself and those close to him, and, thereby, in recovery of energy for constructive expression. The examples given are college students but the ideas, if not the materials used, probably apply to children and adolescents.

Some Cases of Identification

When identification with a character takes place, it involves a recognition of similarity between the character and oneself. A young college freshman, who had never before felt any personal involvement in what he read, commented as follows on Sherwood Anderson's *Winesburg, Ohio*:

The stories gave me a frightened doubt that I myself was being portrayed in an exaggerated fashion.

Since the identification proceeded from a real correspondence between his own motivations and those of the character, his self recognition represents insight. His diction betrays both the shock of discovery and implied distaste. Since the portrayal, however, seemed to him exaggerated, the feeling of recognition was acceptable to him.

If the character with whom the reader identifies is unrealistic in coping with his problems, if his adjustment to life seems maladaptive, the recognition of himself in the character may provide a powerful deterrent to his continuation of his own life pattern. Such was the case of a female Mrs. Mitty, who, on reading Thurber's story, was startled to find that Mitty's fantasies were like her own. While most of the day she envisioned herself in command of her destiny and that of others, the remaining hours she languished in unquestioning subservience to her despotic husband. Her strong identification with Mr. Mitty permitted a detachment that enabled her to become aware of the split in her own life.

Identification may lead, on the other

hand, to augmenting one's self regard through giving one a sense of belonging. A bright twenty-three year old girl, after reading *Sons and Lovers*, confessed with obvious astonishment, "I thought I was the only person in the whole world who had a mother who was possessive and domineering." A disturbed veteran in his late thirties, who had given up a business career and returned to school to study writing, found solace in his identification with writers in whose journals the same kind of doubts and fears that he had experienced were recorded:

I've been thought by my family to be queer and peculiar, but to be humored. My family have tolerated me and humored me, but there is no real kinship. So it helps to read about these people . . . It was wonderful the way Anderson could close up shop and walk away from business and write . . . What made it difficult was my brother was such a dominant person; he accepted the proposition that worldly success was important to achieve . . . Success seemed unimportant to me. I know what I wanted to do—always to write, but doing it was difficult. My brother was indulgent toward me—even my father was—but I had the feeling they both thought I was off my trolley. So these journals you can see gave me a feeling of companionship. I *knew* before I wasn't really alone, but I wasn't able to *feel* it. Do you know how that can be? A person can know a thing in his mind, but he can't feel it. These journals enabled me to *feel* it.

Insight into Other Personalities

In addition to self recognition, identification may take the form of recognition of others. The reader may for the first time see his mother or father with objectivity through the medium of imaginative literature. Such insight may not only be productive of a more realistic attitude toward their limitations and their strengths, but may also bring relief from the anxiety and guilt that accompany feelings of fear or hostility toward them. A Chinese-American girl alternately felt resentful and guilty because she had defied her parents first by attending college and then by refusing to marry the man of their choice for whom she felt no love. She recognized in Christina and Theobald in *The Way of All Flesh* the same qualities that enraged her in her own parents. But she also perceived that they were severe and bigoted, like Ernest's parents, because they had been subjected to pressures beyond their control. This recognition gave her the necessary detachment to continue in college without feelings of ambivalence and guilt.

Alexander and French stress the importance of undergoing a new emotional experience to undo the morbid effects of past emotional experiences. Identification with characters and situations in literature permits a re-experience of the old, unsettled conflict but with a new solution. In some cases the identification is sufficiently strong to take the reader back in time and place to his own childhood. One student, a middle aged teacher, thought at first that *Sons and Lovers* was beautiful:

I spent more time in thinking about it than in the actual reading. It aroused many memories of my early life. They came to me in the middle of the night, in the street car. Memories of my mother, of her death, of her punishment of me, of my brother's scorn of me.

Later she commented on not being able to bear reading it and offered this explanation:

I never loved my mother. That is a dreadful thing to say, a dreadful thing to live through. I was happier when I was away from her. When I came home I was apt to be cross, sensitive, and unpleasant. My mother's spells of blues depressed me. Also she dominated me. I was ashamed of my attitude toward her so I never admitted it. . . . I was entirely too docile all my life, even submissive. That's why I hated the book even while I thought it was beautiful. It made me see how many years of misery I caused myself. I didn't like to admit I was so submissive. Also I didn't like to see my mother as she really was. Since her death I have idolized her. But now I know she wasn't mean like the mother in the book, nor spying and hypocritical. But she was efficient, too busy, ambitious, and brought up to believe in children's explicit obedience. I should wipe from my mind both the picture of a perfect mother and the lingering resentment toward her.

The sympathy engendered for Paul was sufficiently strong to dissolve her own guilt and to uproot her hitherto

repressed feelings. She was able, for the first time, to recognize the hostility she had felt toward her mother. Furthermore, in giving expression to her emotions as well as her reason, she was able to view her relationship with her mother in a new perspective and to differentiate between Paul's mother and her own mother. In so doing she was freed from the ambivalence that had tormented her and was emotionally ready to make the healthy resolution:

I should wipe from my mind both the picture of a perfect mother and the lingering resentment toward her.

The Teacher and Bibliotherapy

We have presented a *rationale* for bibliotherapy and some illustrations of the interaction between the personality of the reader and the characters with whom he has identified, a fusion which has enabled him to re-live and re-assess his own experience. It must be remembered, however, that bibliotherapy is a demanding and rigorous discipline, which is not always productive of insight. Not all teachers are prepared to extend the scope of the reading program in this direction. Nevertheless, in spite of many obvious differences between the training and goal of the teacher of reading and that of the psychotherapist, both are concerned with fostering mental health. And regardless of the intent of the teacher, reading is a complex act involving the whole personality; a source of threat or of solace; a cause of separation of the emotions and the intellect or of their integration. Hence,

the greater the teacher's awareness of the dynamics of reading, the more success will he have in enlisting the imaginative artist as an ally in helping his students find coherence and value in their lives.

For most students a therapeutic approach to reading will be of most benefit as a kind of preventive therapy. At the very least it is likely to arouse an interest in books and help the student to find meaning in them. In some cases there may be a delayed reaction. A book that at the time of reading merely entertained him may become a part of his mind's store of images, a segment of his experienced world, a touchstone for his evaluation of experience, a salutary reminder of danger, a clue to understanding his motives, a clarification of reality, a strategy for coping, or a vision of order. For others there may be immediate results of increased self awareness and

acceptance and a greater capacity to maintain satisfying human relationships. Finally, for some there may be a gradual acquisition of values, an antidote for those unconsciously incorporated from parental admonitions; from the brittleness and cynicism of many Hollywood productions; or from the success myth fostered by "self help" books, resplendent advertisements, and other mass media. Values that will guide and enrich our students' lives will not be superimposed from without but will grow out of the discovery of all of the facets of their personalities, the talents, curiosity, skills, and aspirations that enable them to know who they really are, what they may become, how they may relate to others. To these ends the imaginative writer contributes, for he is able to teach "the human heart, through its sympathies and antipathies, the knowledge of itself."

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1955 Institute on Reading to Emphasize Basic Skills in Reading

Basic Skills in Reading is the theme of the 1955 Institute on Reading, which will be held in Philadelphia, November 15-19. The emphasis will be on differentiated guidance for the development of permanent and worthwhile interests in reading, versatility and independence in phonics, and thinking and related aspects of comprehension.

The Institute will consist of demonstrations, lectures, discussions, and small group seminars. They will be

focused on reading needs in classroom situations from kindergarten through college.

Demonstrators and speakers will include: Dr. Matilda Bailey, Dr. Emmett A. Betts, Miss Dilys Jones, Dr. Ethel Maney, Mrs. Elizabeth Nemoy, Miss Ruth E. Oaks, Dr. Linda C. Smith, Miss Carolyn M. Welch, Mrs. Rosemary Green Wilson, Miss Josephine Wolfe and others.

Persons interested should write to the Betts Reading Clinic, 257 West Montgomery Avenue, Haverford, Pennsylvania.